

ART MUSINGS MUMBAI

art, Menon's gaze is limited to the demotic world around her studio in Nizamuddin Basti in Delhi and the ordinary folk who inhabit it transformed by her mythologising vision. The Malayalis she met at her in-laws in Kerala also step in.

However, the thin layers of paint that she applies add to the lustre of her paintings and enhance their resemblance to early Christian icons. Not surprising for an artist of mixed Bengali and American heritage. Her father belonged to the Deb family of Sovabazar, Kolkata. Her aunt was the writer and social reformer, Tara Ali Baig, who had raised Menon when she lost her mother at 14.

Sounding ebullient, Menon says, "Yes, I am driven to paint. I spend a minimum of three hours a day, sometimes more, on it.... Art is flourishing after the pandemic. Hundreds of young artists are finding buyers and galleries. Art flourishes despite government and bureaucratic indifference." Speaking about the current state of art in India, she says, "There is a turnaround. Beauty will endure. It is no longer a dirty word. Yes, I have always been wedded to aesthetics and in doing so find myself in good company. The work of our most celebrated artists like Husain, Gaitonde, Raza, Ram Kumar, Jamini Roy or Raja Ravi Varma was rooted in aesthetics and they all created works of beauty. At the turn of this century, it's true that beauty became a dirty word, giving way to the so-called cutting-edge where ugliness, anger, the visceral and the political reigned supreme. But post-Covid, there is a huge swing back where present-day artists are once again painting beautiful paintings. Look at the work of Krishen Khanna, Shakti Burman, Paresh Maity or Nupur Kundu or the exquisite sculptures of Anish Kapoor or K.S. Radhakrishnan. Ultimately, beauty will endure."

After a brief stint studying art in Mumbai, Menon earned a degree in English Literature at Miranda House, Delhi, before obtaining a French government scholarship to study at the École des Beaux-Arts in the late 1950s. "Having read the classics in my youth together with the likes of Durrell, Camus and the Beat poets, I now read mostly fiction, Ghosh, Lahiri, Murakami, Tan Twan Eng, etc."

Known to be a champion of freedom of expression, Menon declares: "I tend to be apolitical as politics itself is ephemeral. However, I was very distressed that a great maestro like Husain was virtually thrown out of India on a flimsy pretext. Whatever the future holds for India, as long as we have freedom of expression, artists will continue to contribute to the country's soft power where art is not used for any form of propaganda." ■

–Soumitra Das

show's title is borrowed), a dissident poet who wrote nonsense verse as well as children's books, but whose books, tellingly, never made it to India in translation.

In a marketplace where artists constantly bend over backwards to produce something new, often tripping into desperately new-fangled but pointless attempts, Shafiq manages to deliver both formal innovation and substance for other thought. There is a reason, a logic and a deep humour in the way she invites viewers to pick up the consoles and press the buttons. It is a mark of successful work that one leaves the show with a series of Russian-doll realisations and contemplations emerging one after the other.

TRI is a new arts centre that has just opened in south Kolkata. A typical semi-old (possibly mid-20th century) building has been refurbished, its Art Deco lines both left alone and yet somehow amplified to create a very contemporary art space. TRI has opened with two shows, one of which, *Sea of Fists*, is a wraparound painted piece, a sort of surround mural by Prabhakar Pachpute, with one of his multi-pronged sculptures in the centre. Those familiar with Pachpute's work will immediately recognise the strong and disturbing vocabulary developed by the western Indian painter and sculptor.

SEA OF FISTS is a sort of surround mural by Prabhakar Pachpute, with one of his multi-pronged sculptures in the centre

Against the background of a barren landscape from which all life seems to have been ripped out are shallow cut-outs of figures we know from the dystopic planet of Pachputania—suited men turned into mechanical claws and wrenches, labourers melded into distortions, hollowed-out half-human half-animal beings—all of these punctuated by a form...is it an anthill, is it a volcano, is it a tree stump, is it a toxic dump of industrial waste? The show, again curated by Experimenter, is particularly effective in this environment: south Kolkata's loud and messy traffic just outside, the building with its carapace of frozen entropy, the grids and stairways making a skeleton of minimalist white, providing a loose cage for an oversize identikit dossier of one of India's open-air prisons. ■

–Ruchir Joshi

I Fell Asleep a Believer and Woke up an Atheist by Afrah Shafiq is on at Experimenter, Hindustan Road, till Mar. 2. Prabhakar Pachpute's *Sea of Fists* is on at TRI, Hazra Road, till April 15